

High Impact of a Low-Probability Event: Pearl Harbor

“ . . . So far as relations directly between the United States and Japan are concerned, there is less reason today than there was a week ago for the United States to be apprehensive lest Japan make “war” on this country.

Were it a matter of placing bets, the undersigned would give odds of five to one that the United States and Japan will not be at “war” on or before December 15; would wager three to one that the United States and Japan will not be at ‘war’ on or before the 15th of January (i.e., seven weeks from now); would wager even money that the United States and Japan will not be at “war” on or before March 1 (a date more than 90 days from now) . . . ”

—*State Department Special Assessment, 27 November 1941*

High-Impact/Low-Probability Analysis on 9/11

The 9/11 Commission report includes examination of speculative analysis that was provided to senior policymakers highlighting what were thought to be highly unlikely scenarios that would have a very high impact. One of those items was the 6 August 2001 President’s Daily Brief, which stated:

Al-Qai’da members—including some who are US citizens—have resided in or traveled to the US for years, and the group apparently maintains a support structure that could aid attacks. Two al-Qai’da members found guilty in the conspiracy to bomb our embassies in East Africa were US citizens, and a senior EIJ [Egyptian Islamic Jihad] member lived in California in the mid-1990s.

- A clandestine source said in 1998 that a Bin Ladin cell in New York was recruiting Muslim-American youth for attacks.

We have not been able to corroborate some of the more sensational threat reporting, such as that from a service in 1998 saying that Bin Ladin wanted to hijack a US aircraft to gain the release of “Blind Shaykh” ‘Umar Abd al-Rahman and other US-held extremists.

—*9/11 Commission Report, declassified and approved for release 10 April 2004.*